

AP African American Studies: The Complete Exam Guide

All 4 units explained, the individual student project, the short-answer and document-based questions, and 10 hard source-based practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**2:45**

exam hours
plus a course project

60+5

multiple-choice +
written questions

8.5%

of your score is
your own project

77–79%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

An exam plus a project

Your AP score (1–5) combines a source-based exam with an individual research project you complete during the year. The exam is interdisciplinary, drawing on history, literature, the arts, geography and politics.

60%

Multiple choice • 60 questions

18%

Short answer • 3 Q

12%

DBQ

10%

Project + v...

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Multiple choice	60% of score 1 hr 10 min 60 questions	Sets of 3–4 questions built on primary and secondary sources: texts, images, maps and data.
IB • Project validation	1.5% of score 10 minutes 1 question	A short written response to one oral defense question about your individual student project.
II • Free response	30% of score 1 hr 25 min 4 questions	3 short-answer questions (40 min, 18%): text-based, visual-based and thematic • 1 document-based question (45 min, 12%) using 5 documents.
Individual student project	8.5% of score ~3 weeks in class	Research a topic of your choice, then give a presentation and an oral defense, scored by your teacher.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

INTERDISCIPLINARY

More than a history course

Sources include **poems, speeches, music, visual art, maps and data**. Questions ask you to analyze how each source reflects the experiences and ideas of African Americans and the African diaspora.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 13 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

60 questions in 70 minutes gives you about 1 minute 10 seconds per question. Every set starts with a source, so read the source line carefully.

60

source-based multiple-choice questions

1:10

minutes per question on average

60%

of your total AP score

0

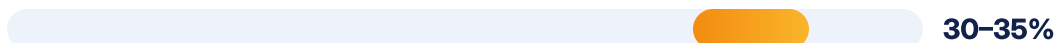
points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

Unit 2

Freedom, Enslavement & Resistance



Unit 1

Origins of the African Diaspora



Unit 3

The Practice of Freedom



Unit 4

Movements & Debates



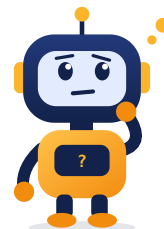
0% 10% 20% 30% 40%

What this means for your study time: Unit 2 (16th century–1865) is the largest. Don't neglect Unit 1: early African societies and the diaspora appear more often than many students expect.

Strategies that work on this section

- Read the source line first: author, date and type tell you the context.
- Identify the claim or purpose of each source before reading the questions.
- Connect sources to broader developments: what was happening at the time?
- For images and art, describe what you see before interpreting it.
- Eliminate answers that are true but irrelevant to this specific source.
- Never leave a blank. Guess and flag at about one minute.

Many sources are **creative works**: poems, songs, paintings. Read them like a historian and a critic at once.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 4 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these four units.

UNIT

1

20–25%

Origins of the African Diaspora

~900 BCE – 16th century

Be ready to: explain the diversity of early African societies, including Aksum, Mali and Great Zimbabwe; trade networks; religious traditions; and the field of African American Studies itself.

UNIT

2

30–35%

Freedom, Enslavement & Resistance

16th century – 1865

Be ready to: explain the transatlantic slave trade and the Middle Passage; slavery's laws and economy; forms of resistance; slave narratives; abolition and the Civil War.

UNIT

3

20–25%

The Practice of Freedom

1865 – 1940s

Be ready to: explain Reconstruction and its amendments; Jim Crow; Black women's leadership; the Great Migration; the Harlem Renaissance; debates over strategies for advancement.

UNIT

4

20–25%

Movements & Debates

1940s – 2000s

Be ready to: explain the civil rights and Black Power movements; links to anticolonial movements; the Black Arts Movement; music and culture; contemporary debates and Afrofuturism.

04

SECTION II

Free response & the project

85 minutes for 3 short answers and a document-based question, plus the individual student project you complete in class.

SAQ 1

SAQ 2

SAQ 3

DBQ • 12%

Project

Short answers 18% • DBQ 12% • Project 8.5% + validation 1.5%

SAQ

Short-answer questions

3 questions • 40 minutes

One is text-based, one visual-based and one thematic (no source). Answer each part with a claim and specific explanation.

Use the source's details, then connect them to a broader development.

DBQ

Document-based question

45 minutes • 5 documents

Write an argument using evidence from the documents. Analyze their perspectives and connect them to the broader context.

Group documents by idea, not by number.

Proj

Individual student project

8.5% • about 3 weeks

Choose a topic, research it with credible sources, and give a presentation with an oral defense in class.

Pick a topic narrow enough to research deeply in three weeks.

Val

Project validation

1.5% • 10 minutes on exam day

You answer one of your oral defense questions in writing, confirming the project is your own work.

Review your project and sources the night before.

◆ A time plan for the 85 minutes

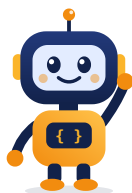
SAQ 1
13 min

SAQ 2
13 min

SAQ 3
14 min

DBQ
45 min

A suggested split, not a rule. Start with the question type you're strongest at, and never leave a question blank.



Your project must be **your own**. Teachers and tutors can teach research skills, not do the research.

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong answer

Here is a short-answer prompt with a strong response, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (SAQ style): Consider a 1920s painting from the Harlem Renaissance showing a crowded jazz club, painted in bold, rhythmic shapes. (a) Describe one way the painting reflects the culture of the Harlem Renaissance. (b) Explain one historical development that helped create the Harlem Renaissance. (c) Explain one way artists of the period used their work to challenge stereotypes.

Sample response

- ① (a) The painting's rhythmic shapes echo jazz itself, reflecting the movement's celebration of music as a distinctly African American art form.
- ② (b) The Great Migration brought hundreds of thousands of African Americans from the rural South to Northern cities such as New York, concentrating artists, writers and audiences in Harlem.
- ③ (c) Artists portrayed Black life with dignity and complexity, countering minstrel-show caricatures.
- ④ Writers such as Langston Hughes and Zora Neale Hurston centered everyday Black experience, asserting cultural pride and the "New Negro" identity.

- ① **Link the visual detail** to the cultural movement.
- ② **Name a specific development** with its effect.
- ③ **Make a clear claim** answering the question.
- ④ **Support with specific examples** of people or works.

Five habits for every written answer

- 1**
Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.
- 2**
Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.
- 3**
Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.
- 4**
Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.
- 5**
Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

African history starts with **slavery!**
(Absolutely not.)



01 Starting with enslavement

Unit 1 covers centuries of African empires, trade and culture before the slave trade.

02 One African American experience

Experiences differed by region, era, gender, class and religion. Avoid generalizations.

03 Ignoring the source type

A poem, a speech and a census table make claims in different ways. Name the type in your analysis.

04 Summary instead of analysis

Explain what a source shows and why it matters, not just what it says.

05 No context

Connect each source to the developments of its time.

06 Treating debates as one view

Leaders disagreed, as Booker T. Washington and W.E.B. Du Bois did. Show the range of positions.

07 Vague evidence

Name specific people, organizations, laws and works.

08 Unanswered parts

Each SAQ part scores separately. Label (a), (b), (c) and answer each one.

09 Project left too late

The project is 8.5% plus validation. Plan your topic and sources early.

10 Diaspora forgotten

The course includes the Caribbean, Latin America and Africa, not only the United States.

Quick self-check: can you name one way the 13th, 14th and 15th Amendments changed the status of African Americans, and one way Jim Crow laws limited those gains?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Analyze one source a day and write short answers every week.



Sep – Oct
Origins



Unit 1

African societies, trade networks and the diaspora. Practice analyzing maps and art.

Nov – Jan
Enslavement +
resistance



Unit 2

biggest unit

The slave trade, slavery, resistance and abolition. Start short-answer practice.

Feb – Mar
Freedom



Unit 3 + your project

Reconstruction, Jim Crow, the Great Migration and the Harlem Renaissance. Complete your individual project.

April
Movements



Unit 4

Civil rights, Black Power, the arts and contemporary debates. Write timed DBQs.

Early May
Sharpen



Full timed sections

Full multiple-choice sets and all written questions under timing. Review your project sources.

Exam day
May



AP African American Studies exam

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 30 multiple-choice questions plus 2 short answers	List your weakest unit
3 weeks out	Source drills: one text, one visual, one map daily	Specific evidence every time
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish every section on time
Final week	Light review: key figures and works, project sources	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **13 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 UNIT 1 • EARLY AFRICA

The wealth of the Mali Empire in the 1300s came mainly from:

- A Atlantic plantation agriculture
- B control of trans-Saharan trade in gold and salt
- C trade with the Americas
- D coal mining

2 UNIT 1 • EARLY AFRICA

The stone structures of Great Zimbabwe are evidence of:

- A European colonial settlement
- B Roman influence in southern Africa
- C a nomadic society with no permanent buildings
- D a powerful African state engaged in long-distance trade

3 UNIT 2 • RESISTANCE

Which is an example of **everyday** resistance by enslaved people, rather than armed revolt?

- A Preserving African cultural practices and slowing work
- B The Haitian Revolution
- C Nat Turner's rebellion
- D The Stono Rebellion

4 UNIT 2 • NARRATIVES

Formerly enslaved authors such as Frederick Douglass published narratives mainly to:

- A entertain Southern readers
- B provide firsthand evidence of slavery's cruelty to support abolition
- C argue for gradual colonization abroad
- D defend the plantation economy

5 UNIT 3 • RECONSTRUCTION

Which amendment guaranteed that the right to vote could not be denied on account of race?

- A 13th
- B 14th
- C 15th
- D 19th

6 UNIT 3 • DEBATES

W.E.B. Du Bois criticized Booker T. Washington mainly because Washington:

- A opposed all education for African Americans
- B called for immediate armed revolution
- C emphasized vocational training while accepting segregation for the time being
- D supported moving to Africa

7 UNIT 3 • MIGRATION

Which factor most directly encouraged the Great Migration?

- A Industrial jobs in Northern cities and the push of Jim Crow violence
- B The end of World War II
- C Free land offered in the South
- D The Homestead Act

8 UNIT 4 • STRATEGIES

The Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955–1956) is best described as an example of:

- A armed self-defense
- B a court case argued by the NAACP alone
- C a Black Power separatist campaign
- D nonviolent economic pressure

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

9 UNIT 4 • DIASPORA

The Black Power movement of the late 1960s was connected to anticolonial movements in Africa mainly through:

- A joint military alliances
- B a single international government
- C shared ideas of self-determination and pride in African heritage
- D opposition to all forms of independence

10 UNIT 4 • ARTS

The Black Arts Movement of the 1960s and 1970s aimed primarily to:

- A create art by and for Black communities that expressed political and cultural identity
- B imitate European art styles
- C avoid political themes
- D focus only on classical music



CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	B	Mali controlled trans-Saharan routes trading West African gold for Saharan salt, the source of rulers' wealth, such as Mansa Musa's.
2	D	Great Zimbabwe's monumental stone architecture shows a powerful state that traded gold and ivory across the Indian Ocean.
3	A	Everyday resistance included preserving culture, slowing work, breaking tools and escaping. The others were armed revolts.
4	B	Slave narratives gave firsthand testimony to persuade Northern readers to support abolition.
5	C • 15th	The 15th Amendment (1870) barred denying the vote on account of race. The 13th abolished slavery; the 14th guaranteed citizenship and equal protection.
6	C	Washington stressed vocational training and economic progress while temporarily accepting segregation; Du Bois demanded full civil rights and higher education.
7	A	Northern factory jobs (especially during World War I) pulled migrants, while Jim Crow laws, violence and poverty pushed them from the South.
8	D	Boycotting buses applied nonviolent economic pressure until the Supreme Court ruled bus segregation unconstitutional.
9	C	Black Power leaders drew on African independence movements' ideas of self-determination and pride in African heritage.
10	A	The Black Arts Movement created politically engaged art by and for Black communities, linked to the Black Power movement.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Practice analyzing one text, one image and one map every day.

10 KNOW THE TARGET How students score

In recent years, about 77–79% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP African American Studies, and about 17–20% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

77–79%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

17–20%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: about **70 s** per multiple-choice question; **~13 min** per short answer; **45 min** for the DBQ
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review the **sources from your project** for the validation question
- ☐ Practice typing a full DBQ in 45 minutes

In the written questions: analyze each source's author, purpose and context, use specific people and works as evidence, label every short-answer part, and build a clear argument in the DBQ.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

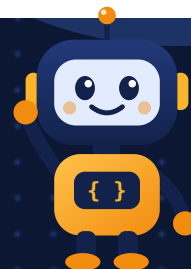
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Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Content tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all four units, with text, visual and data source drills.

Writing & project skills

Short-answer and DBQ coaching, plus research-skills support. Your project stays 100% your own work.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

Web www.actsatgo.com

Email info@actsatgo.com

Phone [+1 \(945\) 391-6179](tel:+19453916179)

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